GLP-1 Receptor Agonist Therapy

Patient Education Handout — Initial Prescription Visit

Medications covered: Semaglutide (Ozempic / Wegovy) • Tirzepatide (Mounjaro / Zepbound)

What Is a GLP-1 Receptor Agonist?

GLP-1 receptor agonists are a class of injectable medications that mimic a natural hormone your body releases after eating. They work in multiple ways to help manage blood sugar and body weight.

Brain	Stomach	Pancreas
Reduces appetite and cravings; promotes fullness signals	Slows stomach emptying so you feel full longer after meals	Stimulates insulin release when blood sugar is elevated; suppresses glucagon

What to Expect: Benefits & Outcomes

Weight Loss

- Clinical trials show **10–20% body weight loss** over 12–18 months with consistent use.
- Results vary; most patients see 1–3 lbs/month early, accelerating as the dose increases.
- Weight loss is *enhanced* by dietary changes and physical activity — the medication works best as part of a lifestyle program.

Blood Sugar Control (if diabetic or pre-diabetic)

- Significant HbA1c reductions (often 1.5–2.5 percentage points) are expected within 3 months.
- Many patients with type 2 diabetes are able to reduce other diabetes medications over time.
- These medications do **not** cause hypoglycemia (low blood sugar) on their own.

Cardiovascular & Metabolic Benefits

- Proven reduction in major cardiovascular events (heart attack, stroke) in high-risk patients.
- Improvements in blood pressure, cholesterol, and liver fat (NAFLD/MASLD) are commonly seen.
- Kidney-protective effects are under active investigation and emerging data are promising.

Follow-Up & Dosing Timeline

Your provider will follow a gradual dose escalation schedule to minimize side effects. The table below outlines typical milestones — your specific doses may differ.

Timeframe	Dose / Check-in	Expected Progress	Lab / Clinical Goal
Week 1–4 (Month 1)	Semaglutide 0.25 mg OR Tirzepatide 2.5 mg weekly injection	Appetite decrease begins; GI side effects peak; 1–3 lb weight loss	Baseline HbA1c, lipids, CMP, weight, BP
Week 5–8 (Month 2)	Dose escalation (per protocol)	GI symptoms usually improve; 3–6 lb additional loss; energy improving	4-week f/u visit; tolerability check
Month 3	Target or intermediate dose	5–10% body weight loss on track; blood sugar trends improving	Repeat HbA1c if diabetic; weight, BP, waist circumference
Month 6	Maintenance dose or continued escalation	10–15% body weight loss expected; significant metabolic improvement	CMP, lipid panel, HbA1c, renal function
Month 12	Long-term maintenance	15–20%+ body weight loss achievable; cardiovascular risk reduction	Full metabolic panel; reassess goals; shared decision on continuation

** Exact dosing schedules depend on the specific medication prescribed, insurance formulary, and your individual tolerability. Always follow your provider's written instructions.*

Common Side Effects & How to Manage Them

Managing GI Side Effects

- Nausea, vomiting, diarrhea, or constipation are the most common early side effects.
- Usually **peak in the first 2–4 weeks** after starting or after a dose increase, then improve.
- Eat smaller meals; avoid high-fat, fried, or greasy foods; stay well hydrated.
- Take your injection on the same day each week; rotate injection sites to reduce local reactions.
- Over-the-counter antinausea remedies (ginger, vitamin B6, Pepcid) can help — ask your provider.
- Do **not** skip meals entirely; this can worsen nausea. Eat bland, low-fat foods if tolerated.

■ When to Seek Immediate Care

- ■ Severe or persistent abdominal pain — may indicate pancreatitis; seek care immediately.
- ■ Vision changes — report promptly; diabetic retinopathy can temporarily worsen.
- ■ Rapid heart rate (>110 bpm at rest) or feeling of racing heart — notify your provider.
- ■ Signs of a severe allergic reaction: rash, swelling of face/lips/throat, difficulty breathing.
- ■ Symptoms of thyroid problems: neck lump/swelling, hoarse voice, trouble swallowing (rare; personal or family history of MTC or MEN2 is a contraindication).

Injection Basics

Where to inject:

- Abdomen (at least 2 inches from the navel), outer thigh, or upper arm.
- Rotate sites each week to prevent skin changes (lipohypertrophy).

How to store your pen:

- Unopened: refrigerate at 36–46°F (2–8°C). Do not freeze.
- After first use: most pens can be stored at room temperature (<77°F) for up to 56 days.
- Keep away from direct sunlight and heat sources.

Missed dose:

- If you miss a weekly dose and your next scheduled dose is **more than 48 hours away**, take it as soon as you remember.
- If the next dose is **less than 48 hours away**, skip the missed dose and resume your normal schedule.
- Never double-dose.

Nutrition & Lifestyle Recommendations

Keys to Maximizing Results

- ✓ Prioritize **protein** at every meal (lean meats, eggs, legumes, dairy) to preserve muscle mass during weight loss.
- ✓ Emphasize vegetables, whole grains, and fiber-rich foods to support satiety and GI health.
- ✓ Limit alcohol — it worsens GI side effects and adds empty calories.
- ✓ Aim for **150 minutes/week** of moderate activity (brisk walking, cycling, swimming) plus resistance training 2x/week.
- ✓ Track weight weekly — not daily — to identify trends without noise.
- ✓ Consider a referral to a registered dietitian or metabolic nutrition program for structured support.

Questions to Ask at Your Follow-Up Visits

- Am I on track with expected weight loss for this point in therapy?
- Do my lab results show the metabolic improvements we were targeting?
- Are my other medications (blood pressure, diabetes, cholesterol) still at the right doses?
- Should I continue at my current dose, escalate further, or hold?
- Are there any barriers to continuing — insurance coverage, injection site issues, side effects?
- Is there any new data about this medication I should be aware of?

Your Provider: _____	**Clinic Phone:** _____	**Next Appointment:** _____

References: Davies et al., Lancet 2021; Wilding et al., NEJM 2021; Jastreboff et al., NEJM 2022; ADA Standards of Care 2024; Endocrine Society Clinical Practice Guidelines on Obesity 2023.